

## The Yoginī and the Tantric Sex Rite, or How to Keep a Secret

Loriliai Biernacki

The *Śilpa Prakāśa*, a medieval 9<sup>th</sup>-12<sup>th</sup> century Tantric manual for temple construction, describes the secret mystical diagram (*yantra*) of the *kāmakalā*, which we can translate as ‘the art of the erotic.’<sup>1</sup> In this text we read: ‘Hear me, I am telling you a secret which you must make great effort to hide’ (Kaulācāra 1966: 2.507). ‘This secret diagram should never be given to any one who is outside of our circle’ (Kaulācāra 1966: 2.536). ‘It is a most secret *yantra*,’ ‘absolutely secret’ (Kaulācāra 1966: 2.538). Ostensibly, the ‘secret’ which must not be revealed to the eyes of the uninitiated has to do with sexual transgression – it is, after all, the ‘art of the erotic’ – so notoriously associated with the yoginī in Tantric practice. I focus in this paper on the role of sexuality in relation to the yoginī precisely because the representation of the yoginī in a variety of Tantric texts, for instance, in the well-known *Kulārṇava Tantra*, is linked explicitly with a kind of illicit and other-worldly sexual encounter with a mysterious woman, the yoginī, who does not figure in the practitioner’s ordinary life. Rather, the yoginī functions as a cypher, a mysterious and extraordinary phantasm of a woman, encountered only in the magical and secret rendezvous associated with the covert occult practices of the daring Tantrika. The purpose of this paper, however, is to call into question this truism of left-handed Tantra, to augment our understanding of the yoginī and the use of the sexual in Tantra to a view more cognizant of the uses of the sexual as ‘advertised secret’ (White 2003: 126; Bledsoe 2000: 195-197).

Let us for a moment imagine the *Śilpa Prakāśa*’s *kāmakalā yantra* in its ritual context. First, we should keep in mind that the *yantra* itself is not figurative, but is rather an abstract diagram of geometric forms, which convey their meaning only to the initiated who know the codes and visualizations (*dhyāna*) connected with the *yantra*. Furthermore, it is quite hidden, carved underneath the statuary on the outside walls of an Orissan temple. Yet, oddly to our eyes, this secret is hidden – as Rāmacandra Kulācāra, the *Śilpa Prakāśa*’s author tells us it should be – beneath erotic scenes of sexual coupling (Kaulācāra 1966: 2.538b; White 1998: 188). Bizarrely, explicit sexual imagery on the walls of the famous Khajuraho temple ‘hide’ this great Tantric secret, ‘hide’ the ‘art of the erotic’, the *kāmakalā*. Moreover, Khajuraho is also well known as

the site of an important temple to the sixty-four yoginīs. Of course, an obvious question arises. Why in the world would one hide this apparently dirty little Tantric secret of sex with an image, which is all the more so graphically sexually suggestive, lifted right out of the notoriously sexually explicit *Kāma Sūtra*? Do we have the right ‘secret’ in mind?

[illustrations 1 & 3]

Tantra, of course, is famous for its secrets, for instance, the double entendre used by secret illicit groups of practitioners, the so-called ‘twilight language’ or *sāṇḍha/ya bhāṣa* of Tantric texts, (Bharati 1993: 169), and the language of *mantras*, masking in secret codes the magic formulas. Yet, what exactly is a secret? Derrida suggests the secret is the space where one reveals precisely in order to keep secret, where one ‘speaks in order not to say anything about the essential thing that he must keep secret’ (Derrida 1996: 59). I suggest a related reading of the secret, however, one that is visually entangled. Sex as secret is the decoy, pulling our glance away from more fundamental issues of power.

That it remains ‘the’ secret nevertheless, has to do with the power of distraction that the enigmas of ‘secret’ and sex hold for us and for them. The tantalizing promise to reveal the ‘secret’ manages to veil the articulations of hierarchy in the social arena. Thus, true to the principle of secrecy that we find pervasive in Tantra, in this paper I suggest that one use of the sexual rite with the yoginī, at least in some contexts, is as a mask for a deeper political and cosmological transgression. The real secret here entails a rescripting of gender hierarchies.<sup>2</sup> The discourse of the secret masks this reformulation of gender and authority in these medieval Tantric texts. This reformulation is revealed visually, in the spatial configuration of bodies. Moreover, encoded within the image, the visual text reverses the gendered notions of body aligned with the feminine, and spirit with the masculine. This hinges upon a visual punning that associates the male with the body as matter.

In what follows I first discuss the sources I use for this paper. After this I address briefly the various explanations for the uses of transgression in Tantra. Following this I discuss the hierarchies implicit in the spatial placement of bodies in Tantric visual imaginal. Finally, I

address the image of the goddess as source of life for the god as corpse and the secret it entails, the feminine as spirit and the masculine as matter.

### *Sources*

The sources that I use for this research include the *kāmakalā dhyāna* of Śiva in the *Śilpa Prakāśa*, the *Bṛhannīla Tantra* and the *Yoni Tantra* (Biernacki 2007: 149-221), in addition to some popular visual representations of a few goddesses. The first text is a medieval 9<sup>th</sup>-12<sup>th</sup> century Tantric manual for temple construction, authored by Rāmacandra Kaulācāra. The latter two texts are late medieval texts, dating from about the 15<sup>th</sup> -18<sup>th</sup> centuries, located in Northeastern India. They present themselves as ‘left-handed’ Tantras, texts specifically purporting to address illicit activities, including especially the sex rite. Neither of these two texts is centrally aligned with the more well-known Tantric schools and lineages such as the *Śrī Vidyā* or the several traditions comprised under the rubric of the Kashmiri Śaiva *advaita* (such as the *Trika* or the *Pratyabhijñā*) or associated schools like the *Krama*. Perhaps as a consequence, English translations have yet to be published.<sup>3</sup> Schoterman notes in his critical edition of the *Yoni Tantra* that this text has an affiliation with the Tantric traditions of *Kāmarūpa* in Kāmākhyā (Schoterman 1980: vii). Of the *Bṛhannīla Tantra*, Goudriaan refers to it as part of the phenomenon of the expansion of Tantras into larger, ‘greater’ (*bṛhat*) extensions. Both texts are Śākta, that is, they explicitly and primarily advocate worship of a form of the Goddess. Formally, both texts are presented as dialogues between the god Śiva and a form of the Goddess, as ‘Devī’ or Pārvatī, the wife of Śiva, or also in the case of the *Bṛhannīla Tantra*, some other goddesses as well, including Tārā, the Blue Goddess of Speech, and some fierce goddesses, especially Kālī and Bhairavī. The *Yoni Tantra* is a fairly short text, eight chapters and only about 219 verses in about sixteen pages. The text focuses explicitly on the worship of women and especially the ritual uses of women's bodily fluids. The *Bṛhannīla Tantra* is a much longer text, some 256 pages, and 2854 verses and is a much more diverse text focusing especially on the goddesses Blue Sarasvatī, Tārā and Kālī, and contains ritual prescriptions, a variety of *mantras* and stories, among other elements. Both of these two Śākta texts' authors are anonymous and the *Bṛhannīla Tantra* likely had more than one author.

## *A Few Caveats*

### *Views of Tantric Transgression*

I do not wish to present the model I give here as the sole explanation for understanding the role of sexual transgression in Tantra. Multiple etiologies, though not always aesthetically pleasing, are a condition of that complex beast we call historical analysis. Tantra encompasses multiple traditions, many different types of texts, many different authors, and a variety of agendas. In any case, a Tantric context naturally lends itself to an awareness of the multiple. For instance, one can point to the pre-eminent philosopher Abhinavagupta, in his *Parātrīśikāvivaraṇa* commentary, where he gives sixteen distinct, even opposing, interpretations for the word ‘*anuttara*’ or the seven he gives for the word ‘*mahābhāga*’. So in a sort of Abhinavaguptian mode, I present here one more interpretation of the practice of sexual transgression, especially salient in some but not all circumstances.

In the interests of space I offer only in broad strokes an outline of various explanations for the transgressive in Tantra for readers not familiar with the subject (Biernacki 2007: 95-100, 253-4). These explanations fall into four basic categories: social, utopic, spiritual, and psychological interpretations, as well as combinations of these. First, regarding the social, we find an explanation implicitly assuming an operative carnivalesque principle of social venting, evoking Bakhtin. This interpretation is painted on the canvas of medieval Indian society as a rigid caste culture, which needed to release the accumulated frustrations arising from rigid hierarchies and uneven power relations. Transgressive behavior is thus part of a cyclical resistance against rigid social rules. Breaking rules periodically by Tantric practitioners is tolerated as a necessary social mechanism designed to let off steam, and is a constituent element in the re-establishment of uneven power relationships (Dimock 1989: 104-7).

A different explanation, frequently aligned with modern Western popular appropriations of Tantra, is a celebration of Tantra as utopic vision, a spirituality-embued sexuality, freed not only from Indian rigidities of caste, but also standing as a counterpoint to modern Western inhibitions and sexual dysfunctionalities (Van Lysbeth 1995; Shaw 1994).<sup>4</sup> In this context, the idea of the yoginī has been appropriated by contemporary feminists as a model for the independent and spiritually advanced woman. Aligned with this, though separate, is a vision of

Tantra as a type of proto-Marxist resistance against social inequalities (Bhattacharya 1996). Other, spiritually conceived explanations see Tantra as a form of spiritual technology, with the use of sex rites as a means of harnessing numinous powers (White 2003). In these contexts, the yoginī has less autonomy and authority; she is the partner that the *yogin* uses to gain magical powers. Similarly, and quite popular, is an understanding that Tantra transgressiveness is not especially corporeal at all, but a metaphoric representation of inner meditative processes (Muller-Ortega 1989). Here the yoginī represents an inner spiritual force, perhaps akin to Jung's notion of the *anima* for the male practitioner. Psychological interpretations include understanding Tantric transgression as a psychological mode for disrupting social constraints of caste (Sanderson 1988; Kinsley 1997). Another psychological strand of interpretation sees Tantric transgressions as part of a deeper psychological dynamic, not necessarily fundamentally tied to the social (Kripal 1998; Caldwell 1999).

My own interpretation here predominantly relies upon a social model with elements of a psychological model. I understand some Tantric transgressions, but certainly not all – notably those associated with a group of late medieval Northeastern Indian texts – as part of a larger social critique, especially of the construction of gender. Of course, the moral of multiplicity here is that it is in fact a mistake to think that such a large corpus of texts could possibly be understood within a single rubric. I suggest instead that different limited groups of texts and movements may operate according to different and sometimes more than one explanation. I focus on a collection of Northeastern Indian texts and its reconstruction of images of gender and the yoginī as the impetus of the transgressive because it affords a productive context for our own understanding of gender.

As a further caveat, at the outset I should make it clear that the sexual ritual, despite its having come to stand in synecdoche fashion for the whole essence of Tantra for the West – one can point to, for instance, workshops by John and Caroline Muir, or a website like [www.tantra.com](http://www.tantra.com), with a header that reads, 'Transform your sex life with 26 hours of video' – despite this, the sexual ritual is by no means, as Bharati seems to suggest, ubiquitous or synonymous with *sādhana* in Tantric texts (Bharati 1993: 228-30). Important texts like the

**IPVV** or the *Spanda Kārikās* do not focus extensively upon it and the majority of Tantra, in the ‘right-handed’ or licit traditions, completely exclude it.<sup>5</sup>

### *Bodies and Hierarchy*

To come back to the *kāmakalā*, I suggest that the ‘secret’ – the social elevation of the feminine and the association of the feminine with spirit rather than body – which is both revealed and hidden finds expression in the visual configuration of bodies. At the beginning of the description of the *kāmakalā* is the *dhyāna*, the visualization of the deity. The *dhyāna* is important because it describes the form of the deity the practitioner imagines. However, the practice of a *dhyāna* does not merely assume that one imagines a god doing this. Instead, following the normative Tantric principle of visualizing oneself as deity, for instance, in the Tantric sect of skull-bearing *Kāpālikas*, the practitioner imagines himself, indeed, ‘practices’ himself in the role of deity. Thus, the *dhyāna* instantiates visually an understanding of deity and cosmos embodied in the human practitioner. In the *dhyāna* of Śiva in the *kāmakalā yantra* in the *Śilpa Prakāśa*, Śiva the god is figured seated below the Goddess, ‘below at the place of the jewel.’ We see in the text:

‘Śiva, the powerful God, Lord of the Art of the Erotic, seated below, at the place of the jewel, sustained in a posture of yoga, deeply absorbed in the dark limbs [of the Goddess], always engaged in sexual union together with the Goddess, who is the great Lady of the Art of the Erotic, always drinking the fluids of the Goddess at the level of third eye.’<sup>6</sup>

In this visualization, Śiva is seated below the goddess Kāmakaleśvarī (*tannimne*) at the ‘place of the jewel.’ This place of the jewel, as David White indicates, refers to the clitoris. Thus, we may read the sexual coupling (*mithuna*) to which Śiva is so attached (*āsakta*) as one where he is below the goddess, rather than one where, if he were practicing the famous *vajrolī mudra* – of Sting-notoriety – of retaining semen, he would be at the same level, or higher than the goddess, (given his taller male physique). In this case, drinking the sexual fluids of the goddess at the level of the third eye puts his third eye at the level of the goddess’ ‘place of the jewel’ and would be in keeping with him being visualized below her.<sup>7</sup> This position, Śiva’s head at the level of the genitals of the goddess is also, in fact, the most practical and easiest way to, as White comments upon it, ‘drink the fluids’ (*rajaḥpāna*) of the goddess (White 1998).

The *Yoni Tantra* as well prescribes just this practice, with a slight variation, again declaring the practice a potent secret which must not be revealed: ‘I’m going to tell you something now you should listen to with attention, understand it well. It should be kept very secret.’<sup>8</sup> The secret here is that the practitioner puts his mouth on the woman’s genitals, and then the text adds, that if, at this time, he repeatedly recites the mantra for the goddess, then the sins he has acquired from a myriad of births are destroyed in an instant: ‘Putting his mouth on the mouth of the female sex organ, he should recite the mantra 10,000 times. This wipes out numerous sins from 10,000 previous births in an instant.’<sup>9</sup>

Leaving aside the raciness of fluids here for a moment, I suggest that the social hierarchy in this context is reflected in spatial arrangements. In other words, the vertical arrangement of cosmos mirrors social hierarchies. To place the goddess at a higher level than the god indicates a social re-alignment of the gender hierarchy. One is reminded here of the many visual representations of the more socially normative god Viṣṇu with his spouse Lakṣmī, where she is both below him, massaging his feet and physically diminutive in relation to him. Nor is this notion simply confined to the Indian context. The infamous ‘missionary posture’ of our own Western provenance not only or simply reflects a physical, spatial position in love-making, but at the same time indicates a social hierarchy, with the spatial configuration of bodies signifying social superiority and inferiority. In this case, I suggest that the spatial relation of these male and female bodies – the god below the goddess, not the sex *per se* – is the ‘secret’ that the *kāmakalā yantra* reveals in its abstract geometric forms and which must so desperately be hidden underneath explicit erotic scenes of sex carved into the walls on top, covering this secret diagram.

If as Pierre Bourdieu suggests, the order of the sexual inscribes our cosmology and the categories we use to structure the world reflect this underlying cosmology, it follows that, a reformulation of the sexual as cosmology can only be read as transgression (Bourdieu 2001: 8, 13-15). Similarly, the *Yoni Tantra* tells us that one gains an excessively special merit if one is able to perform the sex act in the inverted position (*viparītaratā*).<sup>10</sup> This is the sexual position where the woman is on top and the man below. The *Bṛhannīla Tantra* similarly values the inverted sexual position. The Sanskrit word *viparīta* signifies especially a sense of social

transgression, a disruption of social norms. Like the *rajaḥpāna*, I suggest the potency attached to the reverse sexual position is extolled and it must be kept secret not because of the fact of sex, but rather because the spatial arrangement of bodies in the ritual encodes a hierarchy (Bourdieu 2001: 7). It reformulates the normal spatial equation between the sexes; it rather, in fact, presupposes an inversion of the ‘missionary position.’ These details are not without relevance politically.

In an interesting irony, this spatial inversion of gendered hierarchy is encoded in temples across India, even as the significance of this visual transgression is on a popular level not ever articulated. Writing on Śaiva temple ritual, Helene Brunner reconstructs the original model for the establishment (*liṅga sthāpana*) of the aniconic image of Śiva in the temple (Brunner 1998: 95-6). While the central focus of her article is that the installation of the phallic *liṅga* in the temple is indeed a ritual replication of the sexual act, without dwelling at great length on it, she points out a feature relevant for our discussion here – that the positioning of the *liṅga* and the *yoni* (the *liṅga pīṭham* surrounding the phallic icon, the representative of the female genitals in the icon) upsets the normal hierarchy of the genders. That is, it replicates the inverted sexual position. As I have discussed elsewhere, that we should take the transgression enacted here seriously is instanced in that the *Kāma Sūtra*, with its profusion of 84 different sexual positions nowhere includes this particular inverted position.<sup>11</sup>

In this respect, we find related to this another visual representation of goddesses above male consorts. In Tantric contexts that elevate a particular form of a goddess above all other gods and goddesses, we find visual images of these goddesses placed spatially above males. Examples here include the well-known image of Kālī standing astride the god Śiva as corpse in the battlefield. Here theology as cosmology is expressed visually in the elevation of Kālī above the god. Other perhaps less well-known examples include images of Tārā, who is related to Kālī, and portrayed typically as milder, and Lalitā, one of the most important goddesses today, especially popular in South India and the highest deity for one of the most active Tantric schools today. One other goddess who takes this position *vis-à-vis* the god is Kāmākhyā.

[illustration 10 Kamakhya].



I have not been able to find other images of popular goddesses who are portrayed as standing or seated on a male god. Now, interestingly, both of these latter two goddesses are associated with the *kāmakalā yantra* that I began with. This *yantra* is used in the ritual worship of this goddess in the Śrī Vidyā tradition and the goddess Kāmākhyā, the ‘renowned Goddess of sexual desire’ is directly linked to this art of the ‘erotic’. Further, as I discuss elsewhere in terms of subjectivity and gender (Biernacki 2007). The other two goddesses, Tārā and Kālī, are key goddesses in the Northeastern Indian Tantric ‘left-handed’ texts, including especially the *Brhannīla Tantra* and the *Yoni Tantra*, that reformulate attitudes towards women, affording subjectivity to women. Part of the reformulation I suggest here, depends on the visual scripting of both Goddess and God in relative hierarchy. Simply presenting an image of a goddess alone does not go nearly as far in spelling out a social relation between the genders as does this visual illustration of the relationship between the male and female. Cosmos reflects social status.

In these images, the goddesses seated or standing above the god reflects the independent power and authority that the goddess has and the relation between her power and that of the god's. We might also add that this Tantric elevation of a goddess above a male works across the well-know classificatory divide identifying goddesses as either benevolent (*saumya*), and dependent on their husbands, or fierce (*raudra*, *ghora*, Kinsley 1997: 43), and consequently independent and not under the control of a male god. In this case we find both benevolent (*saumya*) goddesses and fierce (*raudra*, *ghora*) goddesses placed above male consorts.

### ***Corpses***

More than this, however, the visual text encodes a philosophical idea. Not only is the goddess in each of these depictions placed above the god, but the god is understood in each of these to be not alive. In the case of Kālī, we have a corpse. In some of these, reading the *dhyāna*, the visualization helps, since the visualization explicitly tells us that this depiction of Śiva in this picture with Lalitā is in fact a *preta*, a ghost. So what exactly is going on here?

These images express a visual theology. The goddess instantiates that power of women, to give life, albeit displaced in this context to the idea of the goddess’ power to give life to the god as corpse. The notion of female sexual fluids of the yoginī and the yoginī’s capacity to give

life reappears here in these images, displaced and visually enacted as a literal, auditory punning. This is encoded in the oft-quoted notion of Śiva as corpse, *śava*, without the feminine principle, *śakti*. This is the significance of the image of the goddess as *śakti* standing on top of the god as corpse. Phonetically, the *śakti* is the letter ‘i’ which, when added to the phoneme ‘śa’, becomes ‘śi’ transforming the dead thing, the corpse – *śava* – into the god Śiva.

If I remind my readers of the profound importance accorded to the phonetic encoding of language, which Padoux so eloquently articulates (1989 and Alper 1989), it is to bring home the importance of this linguistic morpheme in its representation of the *feminine* as fundamentally sentient spirit. It is also pertinent here to recall that in the Kashmiri non-dual Śaiva milieu, the ‘i’ is phonetically also linked with *icchā*, desire, displaying here something like a cultural structuralist association of the feminine and the power of desire, with all its unarticulated connotations of subjectivity (Kakar 1981).<sup>12</sup> The *Bṛhannīla Tantra* also invokes this linguistic pun. The god Śiva says, ‘Without you, o great Goddess, I am the corpse mentioned earlier.’<sup>13</sup> Or again, Brahmā and other gods sing to the Goddess: ‘Without you I would be in the condition of a corpse.’<sup>14</sup> Not a coincidence of course, is what we find again in our secret diagram of the ‘art of the erotic,’ the *kāmakalā*. Notice the large curvy line at the very center of the diagram we saw earlier. This is in *devanāgarī* script the letter ‘ī’. It is again this phoneme signifying the goddess and her capacity to give life as *śakti*.

One may read this linguistic pun in terms of the convergence of metaphysics and psychology. In the lifeless corpse Śiva lying inert on the ground while the wild Kālī stands astride him – and again in the ‘ghost’ (*preta*) Śiva who forms the couch for the Śrī Vidyā goddess Lalitā – and the goddess Kāmākhya who sits on the inert body of the god Śiva – in these Tantric images, the feminine, the goddess, stands as ‘*cit*’ consciousness, life which transforms inert insentient matter, the mere dead thing, the body, into a living moving entity. Here the standard dyad of the male as spirit, enlivening consciousness and the female as body is reversed. Instead the male becomes inert body, the corpse, matter at its deadeast, most insentient. The author(s) of the *Bṛhannīla Tantra* are aware of this and spell the secret out for us in plain terms. The god Śiva here says: ‘O Goddess, I am the body (*deha*), and you are the spirit within the body (*dehin*)’<sup>15</sup> again, reversing the standard trope of female as body and male as spirit. And with this,

the text then proceeds with the rest of the ‘secret’ (*na vaktavyam*), which is the sex rite.<sup>16</sup> Thus the female is spirit against a classical Indian (and our own) conception of the feminine as matter. The male which is historically spirit, *puruṣa*, is instead, matter, the body. This recodes the normative association of gender in the two poles of spirit and matter. This text and these visual images reverse a centuries old political construction of gendered hierarchy. This is the secret the rite hides underneath the distracting veneer of sex. The secret of sex is a secret ‘one speaks, in order to not say anything,’ in order not to reveal the deeper cosmological reformulation of gender as transgression.

But not only here does the return of this repressed understanding of the feminine as the power to give sentience reemerge, albeit displaced. I wish to draw attention to another element of Tantric ritual, which brings together the notion of the body as corpse and the feminine, and again reverses the cosmological encoding. As part of the ritual where the participant goes to the burning ground to sit upon the corpse, the text tells us: ‘Now, he [the practitioner] should always meditate upon you, o Goddess (Śivā),<sup>17</sup> as taking the form of the corpse. Then you will, with a bashfulness, play on the corpse and bring it to life with that form.’<sup>18</sup>

When the practitioner sits on top of the dead body, performing the ritual, reciting mantras and offering incense, etc., to the corpse, he should concentrate as though the corpse were the goddess, and then the goddess will enliven the corpse. Just as with those graphic reversals which Freud noted the *id* reproduces only in the liminal space of the dream, here too, something of a metaphysical punning occurs. As I mentioned, the body, which classically in India references the pole of inert dead matter, as that which, as body, precisely lacks consciousness (*cit*) is traditionally, conceptually associated with the feminine, *prakṛti*. As such it stands in opposition to spirit, body-less consciousness, always associated with the masculine, *puruṣa*. In this context again, however, the terms are reversed. It is the feminine, the goddess which represents the pole of ‘consciousness,’ that can reinsert life into the body. Yet this functions fundamentally as a trope, or perhaps we should read it as a type of psychological displacement of that other insertion of life into matter, which females do by giving birth, a giving of life which is consistently elided by medical and other texts which assert the feminine as mere ‘carrier’ for the male ‘spirit/soul’. The female as mere ‘carrier’ is analogous to the construction of Nature in classical Indian

philosophy, in Sāṃkhya philosophy, as mere, insentient material substance (*upādāna*), the inert ‘clay’ of creation.<sup>19</sup>

To bring this full circle again to female fluids, I suggest that these fluids offer the corporeal, tangible link to the deepest secret of all, which is never spoken, but which yet pervades as the subtext for the secret encoded in the hierarchical spatial contortions of bodies and the Goddess’ power to give life to ghostly gods and ordinary corpses. These powers hinge upon the unspoken yet ubiquitous awareness of the power of a woman, an ordinary woman even, not only the yoginī, to create life out of her body. By the magic of metaphor this power of a woman to create is encapsulated in the image of these fluids as a secret key to divine creative power.<sup>20</sup> Female fluids, indeed, signify a great deal. I suggest here that they are the visual emblem of a woman's power to create life out of her body. I have elsewhere discussed these practices in terms of the ideas of pleasure, desire and subjectivity in relation to gender, (Biernacki 2007: 29-60). So here, it will be offered by way of conclusion that this power to give birth, that female fluids metonymize, is one that has been officially most repressed. One sees this in India, in the ubiquitous assertion of lineage as derived solely from paternity (and in the West as well). One sees this also in the classical theories of reproduction I mentioned earlier, which posit that the male produces the essential thing for the child, the ‘invisible’ spirit, while the woman produces only the body. These Tantric rites with their opaque secrets hidden behind the luring decoy of sex, with the visual encoding of bodies and phonetic punning attempt to address just this secret which must be theologically hidden.

### *Bibliography*

Anonymous (1980) *Yoni Tantra*, J.A. Schoterman (ed), Delhi: Manohar.

Anonymous (1984) *Bṛhannīla Tantra*, Madhusudhana Kaul (ed), Delhi: Butala and Co. Publishers.

Bataille, G. (1984) *Death and Sensuality: A Study of Eroticism and the Taboo*, Salem, NH: Ayer Press.

Bharati, A. (1993) *The Tantric Tradition*, Delhi: Hindustan Pub. Corporation.

- Bhattacharya, N.N. (1996) *History of the Śākta Religion*, 2nd revised ed. New Delhi: Munshiram Manoharlal.
- Biernacki, L. (2007) *Renowned Goddess of Desire: Women, Sex and Speech in Tantra*, New York: Oxford University Press.
- Bledsoe, Bronwen. (2000) 'An Advertized Secret: The Goddess Taleju and the King of Katmandu' in White, D. (ed.) *Tantra in Practice*, Princeton: Princeton University, 195-205.
- Bourdieu, P. (2001) *Masculine Domination*, trans. R. Nice, Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press.
- Brunner, H. (1998) 'The Sexual Aspect of the *Liṅga* Cult According to the Saiddhāntika Scriptures' in Oberhammer, G. (ed.) *Studies in Hinduism II: Miscellanea to the Phenomenon of Tantras*, Wien: Verlag der Österreichischen Akademie der Wissenschaften, 87-103.
- Caldwell, S. (1999) *Oh Terrifying Mother*, New Delhi: Oxford University Press.
- Derrida, J. (1996) *Gift of Death*, Chicago: University of Chicago Press.
- Dimock, E. (1989) *Place of the Hidden Moon*, Chicago: University of Chicago.
- Īśvarakṛṣṇa (1960) *Sāṃkhyā Kārikās*, Calcutta: Firma K.L. Mukhopadhyay.
- Kakar, S. (1981) *Inner World: A Psychoanalytic Study of Childhood and Society in India*, Delhi: Oxford University Press.
- Kaulācāra, R. (1966) *Śilpa Prakāśa*, ed. and trans., Boner, A. and Śarma, S.R., Leiden: Brill.
- Kinsley, D. (1997) *Tantric Visions of the Divine Feminine: The Ten Mahāvidyās*, Berkeley: University of California Press.
- Kripal, J. (1998) *Kālī's Child: The Mystical and the Erotic in the Life and Teachings of Ramakrishna*. 2nd ed., Chicago: University of Chicago Press.
- Muller-Ortega, P. (1989) *Triadic Heart of Śiva*, Rochester: State University of New York Press.
- Sanderson, A. (1988) 'Saivism and the Tantric Tradition' in Sutherland, S. et al. (eds.) *The World's Religions*, London: Routledge.
- Shaw, M. (1994) *Passionate Enlightenment*, Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.

- Torella, R. (1998) 'The *Kaṇcukas* in the Śaiva and Vaiṣṇava Tantric Tradition,' in G. Oberhammer (ed.) *Studies in Hinduism II: Miscellanea to the Phenomenon of Tantras*, Wien: Verlag der Österreichischen Akademie der Wissenschaften, 55-86.
- Van Lysbeth, A. (1995) *Tantra: The Cult of the Feminine*, York Beach, ME: Samuel Weiser.
- Urban, H. (2003) *Tantra: Sex, Secrecy, Politics and Power in the Study of Religion*, Berkeley: University of California Press.
- White, D. (1998) 'Transformations in the Art of Love: *Kāmakalā* Practices in Hindu Tantric and Kaula Traditions,' *History of Religion* 38/2: 172-198.
- (2003) *Kiss of the Yoginī*, Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

## Notes

Unless specified, all translations from the Sanskrit are my own.

<sup>1</sup> The word *kalā* is a good bit more complex than I am representing here. It evokes also the complex system of the *tattvas*, including especially the *kaṇcukas*, sheaths that bind and hence create the individual personality. See White 1998 and Torella 1998.

<sup>2</sup> This principle of multiple masking is not so unlike the transgressive masking celebrated effusively by writers such as Blanchot and Bataille (Bataille 1984).

<sup>3</sup> After I completed my own research and translation, I heard of a recent German translation of the *Yoni Tantra*, which I was not able to locate, and more recently there appeared a translation on the website [www.religiousworlds.com/mandalam/ftp/yni.pdf](http://www.religiousworlds.com/mandalam/ftp/yni.pdf).

<sup>4</sup> Hugh Urban's understanding of the transgression of the Tantric sex rite as an effect of a prurient Western reading of Tantra is in some sense an inversion of the utopic reading. See Urban 2003.

<sup>5</sup> Even if it remains a center of the debate between the Samayācārins and the Kaulas in the *Śrī Vidyā* tradition, it is not at all important for licit, i.e., 'right-handed' Tantra, especially of the variety that I

## outline in note 17 above.

<sup>6</sup> Śilpa Prakāśa, p.82, 2.533-534: *tannimne maṇideśe ca śivaḥ kāmakaleśvaraḥ | īṣat śyāmāṅgaga≤bhīraḥ yogāsanadharo vibhuḥ || sarvadā mithunāsaktaḥ saha kāmakaleśvarīm | ājñācakrasamārūḍho rajahpānarataḥ sadā ||*

---

<sup>7</sup> Again, the text portrays him in a *yogāsana*, not a *kāmāsana*; while the text remains vague here, it would perhaps be difficult to practice *vajrolī* in most of the *yogāsanas* depicted in a text like the *Haṭha Yoga Pradīpikā*.

<sup>8</sup> *Yoni Tantra*, 3.1: *athā vakṣye maheśāni sāvadhānādhāraya | gopanīyaṃ prayatnena na prakāśyaṃ kadācana //*

<sup>9</sup> *Yoni Tantra*, 3.12: *yonimukhe mukham datvā prajaped ayutam yadi | ayutajanmārjitaṃ pāpaṃ tatkṣaṇād eva naśyati ||*

<sup>10</sup> *Yoni Tantra*, 2.21-22a. Also *Bṛhannīla Tantra* 6.76; see Biernacki 2007: 88.

<sup>11</sup> Specifically, the one instance where the woman is on top, she takes on masculinity, *puruṣāyita*, and takes a rod, *sahayya*, which she uses to penetrate her male lover.

<sup>12</sup> This is also a theme that may be culled out of Īśvarakṛṣṇa's *Sāṃkhyā Kārikās* (1960).

<sup>13</sup> *Bṛhannīla Tantra* 18.14: *tvāṃ vināham mahādevī pūrvoktaśavarūpavān*.

<sup>14</sup> *Bṛhannīla Tantra* 12.15a *tvāṃ vinā parame raudri pretatvaṃ gatavān bhavaḥ*.

<sup>15</sup> *Bṛhannīla Tantra* 7.86: *ahaṃ deho maheśāni dehī tvāṃ sarvarūpadṛk*. *Sarvarūpadṛk* as the appearance of all forms, may be a wrong reading for *sarvarūpadhṛk*, 'having all shapes and forms', a reading which does not substantially alter our interpretation here.

<sup>16</sup> *Bṛhannīla Tantra* 7.103ff. The text discusses the practice after the god Śiva in several lines protests that he cannot reveal this, followed by the Goddess' singing a hymn of praise to him, which convinces him to change his mind.

<sup>17</sup> This feminine form naming the consort of the god Śiva also stands as homonym for the word for female jackal.

<sup>18</sup> *Bṛhannīla Tantra* 6.285b- 6.286a: *idānīm śavarūpeṇa dhyāyet tvāṃ satataṃ śive || tadā krīḍasi mūrtyā ca śavopari trapānvitā |*

<sup>19</sup> See Īśvarakṛṣṇa's *Sāṃkhyā Kārikās* (1960). Of course my description here necessarily simplifies the very real complexity of *prakṛti*, 'Nature,' which despite insentience is rather active generally in response to the passive witness that is *puruṣa*, 'spirit.'

<sup>20</sup> Bodily fluids generally in an Indian context are considered impure, contaminating. This in part explains why they must be hidden. I suspect the core of this idea stems from the liminality of the fluid, neither here nor there, the in-between of the process of creating life and again, not inside the body, but outside it, where it does not belong.